

Guiding force: Afsal with his present coach, Ajith, a techie-turned-track coach who provided the nuanced direction that Afsal had previously lacked. M. PERIASAMY

Growing up in Palappuram, in Palakkad, he was first bitten by the football bug.

"Until I was 10, football was my only obsession. I used to play with my dad at a local ground. I loved running with the ball," says Afsal.

But his footballing ambitions ended after his father suffered a leg fracture while playing the sport. Fearing for his son's well-being, Afsal's dad exiled him from the football field.

At that point, Afsal was doing well in athletics at his school, winning medals in sprints and long jump.

That was when a family friend suggested Parali Government School, located 22km from Afsal's home. In appearance, it was a humble institution. But on the track, the Parali school was already churning out champions.

It was at Parali that Afsal met athletics

coach P. G. Manoj, the man who would set him on the path to success.

Even today, Afsal doesn't step out for a race without seeking the blessings of his childhood coach. But their relationship had originally got off to a rocky start.

Still in his rebellious teenage phase, Afsal lazed around in his first year at Parali, never fully committing to coach Manoj's process.

"He used to fake injuries to skip training," remembers Manoj. "There was no ambition. I genuinely had no expectations of him."

At that stage, thanks to his raw talent, Afsal was medalling in district competitions, but had nothing to show beyond that. His idleness, though, was soon upended by peer pressure.

"I started seeing people around me winning medals and getting their photos in the newspapers. I felt that I wanted it too," remembers Afsal.

Gripped by that desire, Afsal put his heart into a 600m race at a state-level meet in Thiruvalla, only to narrowly finish

Afsal's landmark runs



Silver medal — 1:48.43

Men's 800m, Asian Games, Hangzhou, 2023

Indoor national record — 1:47.86

Men's 800m, Bhubaneswar, India, 2026

Outdoor national record — 1:44.93

Men's 800m, Poznań, Poland, 2025

Season's best — 1:46.59

Men's 800m, Oordegem, Belgium, 2026 (as of August 21)

